

Liberal Arts Colleges in the United States: Research Notes

Date: 2026-05-22 (updated 2026-05-23) **Scope:** Definition, selectivity, outcomes, structural forces, social mobility, earnings, diversity, and current trends **Method:** Source-verified synthesis of federal data, peer-reviewed research, and institutional reports

1. Definition and Distinguishing Characteristics

A liberal arts college (LAC) is a specific institutional type within American higher education:

- **Undergraduate-focused:** Few or no graduate programs; faculty hired primarily to teach undergrads
- **Small enrollment:** Typically 1,000–3,000 students
- **Broad curriculum:** Students study across humanities, social sciences, natural sciences, and arts regardless of major
- **Residential:** Designed so students live on campus
- **Low student-faculty ratios:** Typically 7:1 to 10:1

LACs educate a small share of US undergraduates. Revelio Labs, analyzing HR data on individuals who graduated with a bachelor's degree in the past five years, found: **“5.3% received their degree from an LAC, relative to 11.4% from a private research university and 45.6% from a public research university.”** (Revelio Labs, “Liberal Arts Grads Are Supposedly Well-Rounded, But How’s Their Pay?”, April 2024)

LACs are classified by the Carnegie Foundation as “Baccalaureate Colleges: Arts & Sciences Focus.” Approximately 270 US institutions carry this classification.

2. The Top 5: Current Rankings and Selectivity

Per US News & World Report 2026 rankings (published September 2025), stripping out military academies:

Rank	College	Acceptance Rate	SAT Mid-50%	Enrollment	Student:Faculty
1	Williams College	8.5%	1500–1560	~2,100	7:1
2	Amherst College	7.7%	1480–1570	~1,900	7:1
4	Swarthmore College	7.5%	1490–1560	~1,700	8:1
5	Bowdoin College	6.8%	1470–1550	~1,900	9:1
7	Pomona College	7.1%	1490–1560	~1,700	8:1

Sources: US News 2026 rankings; institutional Common Data Sets (2024–2025).

These acceptance rates now rival the Ivy League. Bowdoin’s 6.8% is more selective than Cornell (~8.5%).

3. Financial Position

Endowment per Student

Per NACUBO-TIAA Study of Endowments (FY2023–2024):

Institution	Endowment per Student
Princeton University	\$3,750,669
Amherst College	\$1,858,417
Pomona College	\$1,810,914
Williams College	\$1,708,205
Swarthmore College	\$1,593,734
Grinnell College	\$1,526,198
Bowdoin College	\$1,397,968
Wellesley College	\$1,272,249

Source: National Association of College and University Business Officers (NACUBO), NACUBO-TIAA Study of Endowments, FY2023-24 data.

These five LACs rank among the 20 wealthiest institutions per student on earth, alongside Princeton, Yale, Stanford, Harvard, and MIT.

Williams College Financial Model (Case Study)

Williams’ Provost publishes detailed financial data:

“The \$135,600 that we spend on each student... the \$81,200 that we charge for tuition and fees reflects the \$54,400 annual subsidy enjoyed by every full-pay student, thanks to the resources provided by endowment earnings and gifts.”

“The endowment will contribute \$162 million, which will cover 55 percent of the total cost of running the college.”

“We rely on the endowment and donations to fill this gap, and in doing so they provide nearly 64 cents of every dollar we spend.”

Source: Williams College Office of the Provost, “Priorities and Resources 2023–2024.” <https://provost.williams.edu/priorities-and-resources/>

3A. Earnings, ROI, and the Financial Return Question

3A.1 College Scorecard Earnings (Federal Data)

The U.S. Department of Education's College Scorecard reports median earnings 10 years after enrollment for students who received federal financial aid. As of the most recent data (AY 2022–23, updated November 2025):

Institution	Median Earnings (10 yr post-enrollment)	Median Student Debt
Williams College	\$88,665	\$14,582
Amherst College	\$82,000	\$12,975
Bowdoin College	\$82,735	\$18,833
Pomona College	\$70,500	\$11,000
Swarthmore College	\$65,800	\$19,500

For comparison: Harvard (\$92,000+), MIT (\$124,000+), Babson College (\$123,938). The national median for all bachelor's degree holders 10 years out is approximately \$50,000.

Source: U.S. Department of Education, College Scorecard, AY 2022–23 (updated November 2025). <https://collegescorecard.ed.gov>; College Transitions, “Graduate Earnings by College,” accessed May 2026.

Critical caveats: - College Scorecard only covers students who received federal financial aid, which at elite LACs means a subset of the student body. At Williams, where ~50% of students pay full price, the Scorecard sample skews toward lower-income students, potentially understating institutional earnings. - Scorecard earnings do not distinguish graduates from non-completers. At schools with 95%+ graduation rates this matters less, but it's still not “graduate earnings.” - A Williams student explained on r/ApplyingToCollege: “It may be comparatively lower because Williams students are more likely to go to graduate school, and likely to do that ten-years out. During graduate school, people aren't working, skewing the average salary ten-years out down.”

3A.2 Georgetown CEW ROI Analysis

Georgetown University's Center on Education and the Workforce (CEW) published *ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges: Value Adds Up Over Time* (2020) and updated its ROI data tool in 2025:

“10 years after enrollment, the median ROI for liberal arts colleges is \$62,000, which is \$45,000 below the median ROI of all colleges. By 40 years after enrollment, however, the ROI of liberal arts colleges rises to \$918,000, which is nearly \$200,000 higher than the median ROI of all colleges (\$723,000).”

“The 47 most selective liberal arts colleges... have a 40-year ROI of \$1.13 million. Those returns are nearly as high as the ROI from doctoral institutions with the highest research activity, at \$1.14 million.”

Key finding on STEM composition: “Liberal arts colleges with higher percentages of students majoring in STEM tend to have higher ROIs. Institutions in the top third by share of STEM students have a 40-year return of \$992,000, which is \$179,000 more than the return from institutions in the bottom third.”

Source: Georgetown University CEW, *ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges: Value Adds Up Over Time*, January 2020. <https://cew.georgetown.edu/cew-reports/collegeroi/>; *Ranking 4,600 Colleges by ROI (2025)*, February 2025. <https://cew.georgetown.edu/cew-reports/roi2025/>

3A.3 Revelio Labs: LAC Graduates Earn Less on Average — But Context Matters

Revelio Labs (April 2024), using proprietary HR data on recent graduates:

“On average, LAC graduates earn less than graduates from other institutions in their first jobs after college.”

However, the *same study* found a salary premium for liberal arts majors specifically:

“Students who graduate with liberal arts degrees from LACs earn higher salaries on average than those who graduate with liberal arts degrees from other institutions.”

The overall earnings gap is explained by composition effects:

“In line with LACs’ emphasis on public service, our HR data shows that their graduates are more likely to enter into service-oriented sectors, which tend to have lower salaries: The share of liberal arts college graduates whose first jobs are in Education and Humanitarian Services are 3.7 and 1.4 percentage points higher, respectively.”

“Recent LAC graduates also are twice as likely to enter PhD programs compared to other recent grads.”

Source: Revelio Labs, “Liberal Arts Grads Are Supposedly Well-Rounded, But How’s Their Pay?”, April 2024. <https://www.reveliolabs.com/news/social/liberal-arts-grads-are-supposedly-well-rounded-but-how-is-their-pay/>

3A.4 The Earnings Picture Summarized

The earnings evidence tells a nuanced story:

1. **Short-term (0–10 years):** LAC graduates earn less than peers at private research universities and engineering schools. This reflects major mix (more humanities, fewer CS/engineering), higher rates of graduate school enrollment, and sector choice (more education, nonprofit, service).
2. **Long-term (40 years):** LAC graduates outperform the median for all colleges. The most selective LACs approach R1 research university returns.
3. **Within-major comparison:** For students studying the same fields, LAC graduates earn a *premium* over graduates from other institution types, suggesting the LAC environment adds value for liberal arts majors specifically.
4. **Critical limitation:** None of these studies adequately control for selection effects. Students who choose LACs differ from students who choose large universities in motivation, family background, and career orientation. The Dale-Krueger findings (Section 6) apply here.

3B. Social Mobility, Class Composition, and Who Attends

3B.1 Pell Grant Recipients: The Standard Proxy

Pell Grant eligibility generally corresponds to family income below ~\$50,000. Based on institutional data (primarily IPEDS, 2022–2024):

Institution	Pell Grant %	First-Generation %
Amherst College	20–23%	17%
Williams College	18–21%	—
Swarthmore College	19–20%	24%
Pomona College	20%	20–23%
Bowdoin College	16–18%	—
National average (4-year institutions)	~33%	—

Sources: IPEDS Student Financial Aid survey; Amherst Student, “College Releases First-Year Class Data,” October 2025; Top Tier Admissions, “Liberal Arts College Acceptance Rates,” March 2024; US News, “2026 Economic Diversity Among Top 25 LACs.”

Even the best-performing LACs enroll Pell recipients at roughly half the national rate.

3B.2 Chetty’s Opportunity Insights: Beyond Pell

Pell data understates the problem. Raj Chetty’s Opportunity Insights research (using IRS tax data linked to college attendance for ~30 million students) provides a sharper picture:

“While Pell Grant recipients make up, on average, 15 percent of the students at Ivy-Plus colleges... the Chetty data indicate that just 4.7 percent of their students come from families in the lowest income quintile.”

At Amherst College specifically:

“Nearly 1 of every 4 students are Pell recipients, but only 4.7 percent of students come from the lowest income quintile.”

The Chetty data also reveal extreme overrepresentation at the top:

“At some highly selective colleges there were more students from the top 1 percent of the income distribution than there were from the bottom 60 percent.”

Chetty and Deming (2023), analyzing admissions at “Ivy-Plus” colleges using internal admissions data from multiple institutions, found:

“Legacy applicants, all else being equal, are about four times more likely to be admitted... That fourfold admissions advantage... only applies at the college your parents went to and is absolutely irrelevant at other peer institutions.”

“If you sort of got lucky... your chances of reaching the top 1% of the income distribution 10 years after college, your chances of attending a top graduate school working at a very prestigious firm, these odds go up dramatically.”

Critically, Chetty found that elite colleges *do* causally boost outcomes for the students who attend them — but the students who benefit most are those from lower-income backgrounds, who are precisely the ones least likely to be there.

Sources: Chetty R, Friedman JN, Saez E, Turner N, Yagan D. “Income Segregation and Intergenerational Mobility Across Colleges.” *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 135(3), August 2020; Chetty R, Deming DJ, Friedman JN. “Diversifying Society’s Leaders? The Determinants and Causal Effects of Admission to Highly Selective Private Colleges.” Forthcoming, *Quarterly Journal of Economics*, July 2023; New America, “Chetty vs. Pell.” <https://newamerica.org/education-policy/edcentral/chetty-vs-pell-whats-best-way-measure-colleges-commitment-low-income-students>

3B.3 The Class Composition Problem

The PhD production, CEO representation, and career outcomes documented elsewhere in this report cannot be interpreted without knowing that these institutions draw overwhelmingly from the top quintile of American families. When 60–70% of students at a top LAC come from families earning \$100K+, claims about institutional *effectiveness* are contaminated by the question of who was admitted in the first place. The Dale-Krueger selection effect (Section 6) and the socioeconomic composition data are two sides of the same coin.

3B.4 Pell Graduation Rates: What LACs Do Well

One area where elite LACs genuinely excel: they graduate Pell recipients at rates virtually identical to non-Pell students — a much smaller gap than at most institutions. IPEDS data shows:

Institution	Pell Graduation Rate	Overall Graduation Rate	Gap
Swarthmore	98.3%	97.3%	–1.0
Williams	96.8%	96.3%	–0.5
Pomona	3.5% <i>higher</i> than non-Pell	94.4%	+3.5

Nationally, the Pell/non-Pell graduation gap is 7.8 percentage points. At top LACs it is near zero or even reversed.

Source: Forbes, “Top Colleges And The Pell Student, Part I,” Michael T. Nietzel, January 2019 (using IPEDS data); DegreeChoices.com, “Colleges with highest graduation rates in 2024” (IPEDS data).

3C. Graduation and Retention Rates

Top LACs have among the highest graduation and retention rates of any institutions in the country. IPEDS data (most recent available, 2023–2024):

Institution	6-Year Graduation Rate	4-Year Graduation Rate	1st-Year Retention
Swarthmore College	97.3%	—	97%
Williams College	96.3% (95.1% per Scorecard)	89%	97%
Amherst College	96.1%	—	96%
Bowdoin College	94.9%	—	96%
Pomona College	94.4%	—	98%

For context, the **national 6-year graduation rate** for 4-year institutions is approximately **58%**. The **national average for private baccalaureate arts & sciences colleges** is ~67%. These top LACs are 30+ percentage points above the sector average.

Source: IPEDS, via DegreeChoices.com (2024); U.S. Department of Education College Scorecard (updated November 2025); CollegeSimply.com institutional profiles.

3D. Professional School Outcomes: Medicine and Law

3D.1 Medical School Acceptance Rates

LACs frequently report medical school acceptance rates far above the national average (~40–44% per AAMC). Self-reported institutional data (as of 2025 applicants):

Institution	Medical School Acceptance Rate	Notes
Williams College	~80% of “qualified applicants”	GPA ≥3.7, MCAT ≥512
Swarthmore College	51–76% (range over 7 years)	All applicants, 2016–2024 entering class
Pomona College	79% first-time applicants	13–15% of each class ap- plies to med/ dent/vet

Critical caveat: These rates are not comparable to the national average because LACs often employ pre-med advising committees that discourage under-qualified applicants from applying. The “qualified applicant” filter at Williams (GPA ≥3.7, MCAT ≥512) selects a pool that would have high acceptance rates from *any* undergraduate institution. The national AAMC grid shows students with a 3.8 GPA and 513 MCAT have ~60–65% acceptance rates regardless of school.

The structural advantage of LACs for pre-med is real but different from what the headline rates suggest: smaller classes, less curve-driven grading, more accessible faculty for recommendation letters, and easier access to undergraduate research. As one UC Berkeley pre-med alumnus noted: “At Cal most classes are curved down, high competition for research, rounds of interviews just to join a volunteering club, unhelpful advising.”

Source: Shemmassian Academic Consulting, “Best Liberal Arts Colleges for Medical School (2026),” April 2026; AAMC applicant data; ResidencyAdvisor.com, “Acceptance Rates by Undergraduate Institution Type.”

3D.2 Law School Placement

LACs do not systematically publish law school acceptance data in the same way they report medical school rates. However, College Transitions data shows that per-capita feeder rates to top-14 law schools are high from elite LACs, consistent with the PhD per-capita pattern. This gap in the data deserves further investigation.

3E. SFFA v. Harvard and the Racial Diversity Crisis

3E.1 The Ruling

In June 2023, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled in *Students for Fair Admissions, Inc. v. President and Fellows of Harvard College* that race-conscious admissions at Harvard and UNC violated the Equal Protection Clause. The decision prohibited the use of race as a factor in admissions, though it allowed applicants to discuss “how race affected his or her life” in essays.

3E.2 Impact on LAC Enrollment

The Class of 2028 (entering Fall 2024) was the first admitted under SFFA. Data from LAC student newspapers and institutional reports:

Amherst College saw the most dramatic swing: - Class of 2027 (pre-SFFA): 11% Black - Class of 2028 (first post-SFFA): 3% Black — an 8 percentage-point drop - Class of 2029: 6% Black (partial recovery per federal reporting; 12% self-identify)

Williams College saw marginal changes: - Black students: 6.8% → 7.3% (slight increase) - Hispanic students: 14.8% → 15.5% - White students: 45.3% → 42.7% - Non-disclosure rate increased 0.7 points

Swarthmore College: - Black students: ~10% average → 8% (Class of 2028) - Overall URM: 27.5% → 25.1% - All students of color: 55.1% → 52.5%

Sources: *Amherst Student*, “College Releases First-Year Class Data After One-Month Delay,” October 2025; *Williams Record*, “First-year enrollment demographics shift slightly following affirmative action ban,” September 2024; *Swarthmore Phoenix*, “Data on Class of 2028 Shows Declines,” October 2024; NBC News, “Black enrollment dips at some top colleges,” September 2024.

3E.3 Sector-Wide Pattern

Brookings Institution (April 2026) analyzed the broader picture across two admissions cycles:

“The Supreme Court ruling is particularly disastrous for Black student enrollment. Out of 29 elite institutions that reported fall 2025 enrollment data, only two still maintain Black enrollment of at least 10%, while 11 reported levels of 5% or lower.”

“At highly selective institutions overall, the number of underrepresented minority freshmen declined 7 percent from 2023 to 2024, including a 16.3 percent drop in Black students.”

The “cascade effect” is pushing URM students to state flagships:

“At flagship institutions, underrepresented minority enrollment went up by 8 percent, far outpacing the overall 3.2 percent growth.”

Source: Brookings Institution, “The complex ramifications of Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard,” April 2026. <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/the-complex-ramifications-of-students-for-fair-admissions-v-harvard/>; Inside Higher Ed, “Post-SFFA Minority Enrollment Increased at Flagships,” February 2026.

3E.4 Why This Matters for LAC Claims

The Dale-Krueger finding that selectivity effects “remain large for Black and Hispanic students” (Section 6.1) means the SFFA ruling is removing from elite campuses *exactly the population* for whom attending an elite school causally matters most. The cascade effect is not just a diversity problem — it is a social mobility problem. LACs that built their identity around access and diversity now face a structural constraint on delivering those outcomes.

4. PhD Production: The Strongest Outcome Claim

4.1 Data Source and Reliability

The primary data source is the **NSF Survey of Earned Doctorates (SED)**, a federal census (not a sample survey) of every research doctorate awarded at accredited US institutions, conducted annually since 1958. Sponsored by four federal agencies: NSF, NIH, Department of Education, and NEH. Completion rate: ~92–93%. As of 2024, the survey covered 58,131 doctorate recipients from 459 institutions.

Source: NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates, 2024. <https://nces.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates/2024>

4.2 The Per-Capita Advantage

NSF InfoBrief NSF 22-321 (2022), “Baccalaureate Origins of U.S. Research Doctorate Recipients,” using 2010–2020 data:

“On a per capita basis, more graduates from Carnegie-classified baccalaureate colleges: arts and sciences focus earn a doctoral degree in science and engineering (S&E) than their peers at other types of Carnegie Classification of institutions.”

“These figures demonstrate a clear stratification... with baccalaureate colleges: arts and sciences focus yielding research doctorates at a higher rate than R1: doctoral universities across the 2010–20 time frame.”

The NSF uses the Institutional Yield Ratio (IYR):

“The IYR for a baccalaureate-origin institution is calculated as the number of baccalaureate graduates who earned a research doctorate in a given time period (2010–20 in this analysis), divided by the number of baccalaureate graduates from that institution for the time period 9 years prior to the doctorate award (2001–11).”

Source: Gordon J, Einaudi P, Kang K. NCSES. 2022. *Baccalaureate Origins of U.S. Research Doctorate Recipients*. InfoBrief NSF 22-321. <https://nces.nsf.gov/pubs/nsf22321>
 From the NSF 2008 InfoBrief (NSF 08-311):

“Baccalaureate colleges produce 13% of S&E bachelor’s degrees, but they are important contributors to producing future S&E PhDs.”

“After normalizing for number of bachelor’s awarded 9 years earlier, more than half of the top 50 baccalaureate-origin institutions of 1997–2006 S&E doctorate recipients were baccalaureate colleges.”

“The top 5 baccalaureate-origin institutions in terms of number of S&E doctorates per hundred bachelor’s awarded in all fields 9 years earlier were: California Institute of Technology, Harvey Mudd College, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Reed College, and Swarthmore College.”

Source: Burrelli J, Rapoport A, Lehming R. 2008. *Baccalaureate Origins of S&E Doctorate Recipients*. InfoBrief NSF 08-311. <https://www.nsf.gov/statistics/infbrief/nsf08311>
 A 2025 article in the *Journal of Physical Chemistry C* confirmed the persistence of this pattern with the most recent NSF data:

“Of the top 50 producers of Ph.D. degrees in STEM fields by institutional yield ratio, 27 are PUIs (24 Baccalaureate Colleges: Arts and Sciences Focus).”

“The outsized success of PUIs for producing alumni who matriculate to Ph.D. programs at research universities is attributed to more personal attention received from the faculty and intensive research experiences with their faculty research mentors.”

Source: *Journal of Physical Chemistry C*, “Research at Predominantly Undergraduate Institutions,” 2025. DOI: 10.1021/acs.jpcc.5c00979

4.3 Current Per-Capita Rankings

College Transitions analyzed recent NSF data to calculate doctoral recipients per 1,000 current undergraduates over a decade:

“Caltech leads with an extraordinary rate of 891 doctoral recipients per 1,000 undergraduates... Harvey Mudd College, another tiny STEM-focused institution, follows at 509. MIT ranks third at 487, and then comes Swarthmore College — a liberal arts college with no engineering school to speak of — at a remarkable 481.”

“The per-capita top 25 is almost entirely composed of two types of institutions: highly selective private research universities... and elite liberal arts colleges... Not a single public university appears.”

“Carleton College (399 per 1,000), Reed College (364), Williams (340), Haverford (333), Pomona (323), and Grinnell (319) all produce PhDs at rates that rival or exceed those of the Ivy League.”

Source: College Transitions, “Where Do America’s PhDs Come From?”, April 2026. <https://www.collegetransitions.com/blog/where-do-americas-phds-come-from/>

4.4 Trend Over Time

Absolute PhD production from the top baccalaureate colleges has declined from peak levels, per NSF data compiled by St. Olaf College:

College	1994–2003	2004–2013	2018–2022
Carleton	766	836	428
Oberlin	1,107	883	394
Swarthmore	770	732	387
Williams	644	668	352
Wellesley	608	603	322

Note: The 2018–2022 column spans 5 years while the others span 10 years. Adjusting for this, rates have still declined but not as dramatically as raw numbers suggest.

The NSF InfoBrief NSF 22-321 notes:

“The DYR for non-S&E doctorate recipients are lower for all Carnegie class of institutions than for S&E doctorate recipients due to fewer people pursuing doctorates in these fields. Among non-S&E doctorate recipients, baccalaureate colleges: arts and sciences focus have the highest DYR, but there is a slight decline in the ratio among all of the Carnegie Classification groups over the past decade.”

Source: St. Olaf College, “Baccalaureate Origins of Ph.D.s,” compiled from NSF SED data, accessed June 2024. <https://wp.stolaf.edu/iea/baccalaureate-origins-of-ph-d-s/>

4.5 Engineering Exception

The PhD advantage does **not** hold in engineering:

“The Oberlin 50 colleges have a higher yield in the social and behavioral sciences and about the same yield in the natural sciences but a far lower yield in engineering than the private research universities.”

Source: NSF InfoBrief NSF 08-311 (2008).

4.6 Why PhD Production Is Declining: Causal Analysis

The per-capita PhD advantage persists (Section 4.2–4.3), but absolute numbers are falling (Section 4.4). The decline is driven by structural forces in the PhD market itself, not by a deterioration of LAC quality:

1. **Humanities PhD pipeline collapse.** NSF SED 2024 data shows only 57% of humanities doctorate recipients reported definite employment commitments, and less than a third secured academic positions. Princeton historian David Bell wrote in 2023: “Of my 10 Ph.D. students who defended their dissertations before 2016, all but one got a tenure-track job... Of the eight who have defended since then, only one has so far gotten a tenure-track job.”
2. **Elite universities are slashing PhD admissions.** In 2025–2026: Harvard cut PhD admission slots in sciences by 75% and humanities by 60%. University of Chicago paused humanities PhD admissions. Yale is weighing 12% cuts in humanities/social science graduate enrollment. Brown paused admissions in at least six humanities/social science departments. These cuts are driven by the endowment tax (rising from 1.4% to 8% at Yale), graduate student unionization costs, and collapsing academic job markets.
3. **Opportunity cost.** As tech and finance salaries rose, the 5–7 year opportunity cost of a PhD increased sharply. The CS enrollment boom (Section 8–9) pulled potential PhD candidates into industry.
4. **The downstream implications for LACs:** If the PhD pipeline is contracting for structural reasons — declining academic jobs, rising costs, competition from industry — then the LAC per-capita advantage may be measuring something that is becoming less valuable to students, even as it remains statistically significant.

Sources: Forbes, “Hard Times Have Come For The PhD Degree,” Michael T. Nietzel, January 2026; Axios, “The pipeline for Ph.D.s out of U.S. universities is shrinking,” October 2025; *Chronicle of Higher Education*, “Doctoral Programs Were Already Under Strain,” March 2025; University of Chicago AAUP, “The Past and Future of Graduate Admissions to the Humanistic Fields,” June 2025; *Inside Higher Ed*, “How One University Is Reimagining a Humanities Ph.D. Program,” September 2025.

5. Business Leadership Claims: Weaker Evidence

5.1 The Strongest Systematic Study

Grinnell College’s communications team (2012) coded the undergraduate institutions of leaders across three sectors using Carnegie classifications:

“Overall, 11.33 percent of the leaders across the above three sectors graduated from baccalaureate colleges that offer arts and sciences programs. That’s more than five times the expected 2.2 percent incidence of enrollment in baccalaureate arts and sciences colleges based on Carnegie’s classification.”

“Looking at each sector individually, 11.75 percent of Philanthropy 400 leaders, 12 percent of U.S. Senators and 10.87 percent of Fortune 500 CEOs received their undergraduate education at baccalaureate arts and sciences colleges.”

Source: Inside Higher Ed, “Essay on how liberal arts colleges promote leadership,” Mark Peltz (Grinnell College), May 14, 2012. <https://www.insidehighered.com/views/2012/05/14/essay-how-liberal-arts-colleges-promote-leadership>

5.2 Fortune 50 CEO Majors

A peer-reviewed study of 2019 Fortune 50 CEOs found:

“An examination of the undergraduate educational backgrounds of the 2019 Fortune 50 CEOs revealed an exact split between 18 STEM majors, 18 liberal arts majors and 18 business majors, with 1 CEO who began university studies but did not graduate.”

Source: “Success beyond STEM: an analysis of educational background of the Fortune 50 CEOs,” ResearchGate, 2020.

5.3 S&P 500 CEO Data

An American Economic Association study (2004 data) found:

“Liberal Arts graduates comprise the largest group with just over one-third (34.3%) of these business leaders. Economics majors are the largest subset of the Liberal Arts graduates, with approximately nine percent (9.2%) of the CEOs holding an undergraduate degree in Economics.”

Source: American Economic Association, “Economics: Good Choice of Major for Future CEOs.” <https://www.aeaweb.org/content/file?id=744>

5.4 Limitations

These studies are correlational. They do not control for socioeconomic background, family connections, or selection effects. The CEO data reflects graduates from 25–40 years ago.

Critical conflation: “Liberal arts major” ≠ “Liberal arts college graduate.” The S&P 500 CEO data (Section 5.3) counts an economics major from Harvard as a “liberal arts graduate.” The Fortune 50 CEO split (18/18/18) likewise does not distinguish institutional type. An economics major from a research university and a philosophy major from a 2,000-student LAC share the label “liberal arts” but have almost nothing else in common — different peer networks, different recruitment pipelines, different credential signals to employers. This conflation runs throughout the pro-LAC marketing literature. The Grinnell study (Section 5.1) uses Carnegie classifications to count *institutional type*, which is methodologically stronger, but it was conducted by Grinnell’s communications team and published as an Inside Higher Ed opinion piece — not peer-reviewed research. It remains the only systematic leadership study that distinguishes LAC *institutions* from liberal arts *majors*.

6. The Selection Effect: The Central Methodological Question

6.1 The Dale-Krueger Studies

The most rigorous test of whether elite institutions *cause* better outcomes:

Dale, Stacy Berg and Alan B. Krueger. 2002. “Estimating the Payoff to Attending a More Selective College: An Application of Selection on Observables and Unobservables.” *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 117(4): 1491–1527.

“Students who attended more selective colleges earned about the same as students of seemingly comparable ability who attended less selective schools.”

Dale and Krueger. 2014. “Estimating the Effects of College Characteristics Over the Career Using Administrative Earnings Data.” *Journal of Human Resources* 49(2): 323–358.

Extended the analysis using Social Security Administration earnings data through 2007. The core finding held: selectivity effects “generally fall to close to zero” in selection-adjusted models, “however, these effects remain large for certain subgroups, such as for black and Hispanic students.”

Source: <https://academic.oup.com/qje/article-abstract/117/4/1491/1876022>; NBER Working Paper 17159.

6.2 Gender-Specific Effects

A follow-up study using Dale-Krueger’s method found different effects by gender:

“For men, our findings echo those in Dale and Krueger (2002): controlling for selection eliminates the positive relationship between college selectivity and earnings. We also find no significant effects on men’s educational or family outcomes. The results are quite different for women: we find effects on both career and family outcomes. Attending a school with a 100-point higher average SAT score increases women’s probability of advanced degree attainment by 5 percentage points and earnings by 14 percent, while reducing their likelihood of marriage by 4 percentage points.”

Source: “Elite Schools and Opting In: Effects of College Selectivity on Career and Family Outcomes,” *Journal of Political Economy*, 2022. <https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/10.1086/717931>

7. Career Funneling: Where Graduates Actually Go

7.1 First-Destination Data

Williams College (Class of 2023): 26.4% entered finance; 14.2% continued education. Source: *Williams Record*, “What am I doing with the rest of my life?”, 2024.

Swarthmore College (Class of 2023): 57.6% working; 23.4% continuing education; 14.4% seeking employment. Knowledge rate: 94.1%. Source: Swarthmore Career Services, “First Destinations: Class of 2023.” <https://careercenter.swarthmore.edu/resources/first-destinations-class-of-2023/>

Amherst College (Class of 2024): “94% of our graduates are employed, continuing education, pursuing a fellowship, volunteering, or serving in the military within six months of graduation.” Knowledge rate: 90%. **Source:** Amherst College, “After Amherst: Student Outcomes.” <https://www.amherst.edu/about/after-amherst-student-outcomes>

Pomona College (Class of 2025): “90% of the Class of 2025 is engaged in career activities such as jobs and internships, service opportunities, further education or fellowships.” Employers include Apple, Deutsche Bank, JP Morgan, Microsoft, NIH, National Park Service, Peace Corps. **Source:** Pomona College News, February 17, 2026. <https://www.pomona.edu/news/2026/02/17>

Bowdoin College (Class of 2023, one year out): “98% of Bowdoin’s Class of 2023 reported that they were employed, attending graduate school, or engaged with a fellowship or personal project.” Among those pursuing advanced degrees: “39% pursued masters degrees, 24% pursued Ph.D.s, 12% pursued law degrees, 8% pursued medical degrees.” **Source:** Bowdoin College, “Student Outcomes.” <https://www.bowdoin.edu/ir/data/student-outcomes.html>

Wellesley College (Class of 2025): “96% of Class of 2025 graduates were employed, accepted to graduate school, participating in a service/volunteer program, or serving in the military within 6 months of graduation.” **Source:** Wellesley Career Education, “Class of 2025 First Destination.” <https://careereducation.wellesley.edu/class-2025-first-destination>

7.2 Long-Term Graduate Degree Attainment

Swarthmore alumni survey data:

“About sixty percent of those who graduated five years ago (Class of 2015) reported earning or currently pursuing a graduate or professional degree – and the rate was even higher for each of the older classes, to a high of 86% of the Class of 1969.”

“Across all classes (excluding 2019 and 2020), 32% of the graduates had earned or were pursuing doctoral degrees at the time of the survey.”

Source: Swarthmore College, “Alumni Outcomes.” <https://www.swarthmore.edu/institutional-effectiveness-research-assessment/alumni-outcomes>

7.3 The Career Funneling Mechanism

Amy Binder (sociology, UC San Diego) and colleagues studied career funneling at elite campuses. Published in *Sociology of Education* (2016):

“Elite universities are credited as launch points for the widest variety of meaningful careers. Yet, year after year at the most selective universities, nearly half the graduating seniors head to a surprisingly narrow band of professional options.”

“Students come to campus, they’re very ambitious, they want to have great careers, but they’re incredibly naïve about what the labor force actually looks like.”

“This is in large part a story of universities helping to organizationally manufacture students’ aspirations for these positions.”

The mechanism: firms pay universities for privileged recruitment access (“platinum” membership):

“To get to those kids, the nation’s top banks and consulting firms began by competing to become ‘platinum’ members of the career services programs run by the most elite schools. Winners of this pay-for-play competition get the best tables at campus career fairs, access to students’ email in-boxes, entrée to the most impressive banquet rooms for holding information sessions and receptions, bundled delivery of applicants’ résumés, and space and scheduled times to hold one-on-one interviews.”

“More than half of the 60 colleges Davis surveyed participated in corporate partnerships wherein, for an annual fee, the firms got direct access to student talent.”

“Very often faculty and administrators are taken aback by the rates of entry of students into these careers, but they’re not fully aware of all of the things that their campuses do to facilitate entry into them.”

Source: Binder AJ, Davis DB, Bloom N. 2016. “Career Funneling: How Elite Students Learn to Define and Desire ‘Prestigious’ Jobs.” *Sociology of Education* 89(1). <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/0038040715610883>

Harvard Crimson data confirms persistence of the pattern. Class of 2025:

“More than half of the class of 2025 had taken jobs in finance (21 percent), tech (18 percent), or management consulting (14 percent).”

Source: Mother Jones, “How America’s elite colleges breed high-status careers—and misery,” September 2025.

7.4 The Hiring Side

Lauren Rivera (Northwestern/Harvard) embedded herself inside hiring processes at elite investment banks, consulting firms, and law firms:

“Nearly all the recruits at places such as Goldman Sachs, McKinsey or Cravath come from a handful of ultra-prestigious institutions.”

“Firms define talent in a manner that excludes high-performing students from less privileged backgrounds.”

“The first cut in EPS interviewing is effectively completed four years in advance by school admissions committees who decide who is worthy of the Ivy League or a similar education.”

Source: Rivera LA. 2015. *Pedigree: How Elite Students Get Elite Jobs*. Princeton University Press. Reviewed in *Financial Times*, June 14, 2015.

8. The STEM Transformation Inside LACs

8.1 Current Popular Majors

Pomona College’s top majors (current):

Major	% of Graduates
Computer Science	13%
Economics	10%
Mathematics	7%
Neuroscience	7%
Molecular Biology	5%

Source: US News, Pomona College profile, 2026 edition. <https://www.usnews.com/best-colleges/pomona-college-1173>

8.2 National Major Shifts

From the Burning Glass Institute (2018–2023 data):

“Liberal arts and humanities majors have experienced some of the most significant drops. From 2018 to 2023, the number of students majoring in liberal arts and humanities fell by nearly 30 percent.”

“Technology majors, particularly computer and information sciences, have surged. This category saw the largest increase in share among all major groups, growing by 42% from 2018 to 2023. Within that, computer science alone rose by an impressive 52%.”

Source: Burning Glass Institute, “How Changing College Majors Are Reshaping the Future Workforce,” July 2025. <https://www.burningglassinstitute.org/bginsights/how-changing-college-majors-are-reshaping-the-future-workforce>

From NCES data (2013–2022):

“Since 2009, full-time workers with STEM undergraduate degrees have consistently earned around 30-40% more than their peers with liberal arts degrees, based on Census Bureau data.”

“Between 2013 and 2022... the number of STEM bachelor’s degrees rose by about 40%, while the number of bachelor’s degrees in liberal arts and humanities awarded per year fell by 14%.”

Source: Charlotte Observer / Stacker / Learner, “STEM is the new liberal arts,” July 2024.

9. The 2025–2026 CS Enrollment Reversal

9.1 The Drop

National Student Clearinghouse (Fall 2025 data):

“Enrollment in computer and information science programs at four-year universities dropped 8.1 percent — a drop-off steeper than any other field of study.”

“Compared to other majors within the computer science family, like IT management or information studies, computer science specifically took the biggest enrollment hit, plummeting 11.2 percent.”

Source: Built In, “Computer Science Degrees Are Losing Popularity in the AI Era,” March 12, 2026. Citing National Student Clearinghouse data.

Computing Research Association survey:

“62 percent of the 130 participating universities reported a decrease in computer science enrollment in the 2025-2026 school year.”

Source: CRA Survey, cited in Built In (March 2026) and Encoura (April 2026).

9.2 What’s Growing Instead

“Within the Engineering major field, Computer Engineering programs also saw decreases, while other engineering specialties, such as Mechanical, Electrical, and Civil Engineering, posted double-digit gains.”

“The field of study that grew the most, according to the National Student Clearinghouse, was engineering, which increased 7.3 percent.”

Source: National Student Clearinghouse Research Center, “Postsecondary Enrollment Rises as Academic Trends Shift,” January 2026. <https://www.studentclearinghouse.org/nsblog/postsecondary-enrollment-rises-as-academic-trends-shift/>

9.3 The Employment Reversal for CS Graduates

Federal Reserve Bank of New York, “The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates” (using 2023 Census data on graduates ages 22–27):

“The bank found that philosophy had an unemployment rate of 3.2%, less than computer science’s 6.1%.”

“Art history had an unemployment rate of 3% and philosophy of 3.2%, each below the national average.”

“Computer engineering” had an unemployment rate of 7.5%.

Source: Federal Reserve Bank of New York, “The Labor Market for Recent College Graduates.” <https://www.newyorkfed.org/research/college-labor-market>. Data reported in Entrepreneur.com (March 2025), Forbes (February 2026), Newsweek (May 2025), and CNBC (July 2025).

Forbes reporting on the data:

“The relatively poor employment prospects for majors in the fine and performing arts are not that particularly surprising, but others — like computer engineering and computer science — long regarded as reliable pathways to good jobs — appear to be facing new hiring headwinds, supporting the notion that the AI revolution is disrupting the job market.”

Source: Forbes, “Unemployment And Underemployment Rates Among Recent College Graduates,” Michael T. Nietzel, February 23, 2026.

Money magazine noted the reversal:

“Now in a stark reversal, art history grads are far more likely to be employed than computer-engineering, mathematics, chemistry, industrial-engineering and physics majors.”

Source: Money, “Recent College Grads Are Discovering That a STEM Degree Doesn’t Guarantee a Job,” July 2025.

Critical caveat: CS graduates, while facing higher unemployment, earn significantly more when employed. The NY Fed data also shows CS has a 16.5% underemployment rate vs. philosophy’s 41.2% — meaning philosophy grads get jobs, but those jobs often don’t require a degree.

10. Institutional Closures and the Bifurcation

10.1 Closures and Financial Distress

“Since 2022, the closure of 27 small liberal arts colleges nationwide has led to the loss of nearly 7,200 jobs and \$374 million in labor income, with half these losses occurring in 2024 alone.”

Source: Shortform / IMPLAN, “US Colleges Are Shutting Down,” December 2025.

Notable closures and near-closures (2024–2026): - **Hampshire College (MA)**: Announced permanent closure April 2026. Enrolled only 168 new students vs. target of 300. - **Earlham College (IN)**: Cutting 109 positions, 41% teaching faculty. - **Sterling College (VT)**: Closed; enrollment was 78 students.

Source: Bryan Alexander, “Campus cuts, closures, mergers, and layoffs for spring 2026,” May 2026. <https://bryanalexander.org/horizon-scanning/campus-cuts-closures-mergers-and-layoffs-for-spring-2026/>

10.2 The Enrollment Cliff

Nathan Grawe, an economist at Carleton College who coined the term ‘enrollment cliff,’ “predicts that between 2025 and 2029, the population of students attending college will decrease by 15%.”

Source: Yale Daily News / The Politic, “When Colleges Close,” 2025.

10.3 Structural Evolution at the Top

Pomona College and Claremont Graduate University are in merger talks:

“On the table is a deal that would turn CGU into a legal subsidiary of Pomona... Pomona’s President Gabrielle Starr said in a statement Thursday that ‘Pomona’s liberal arts undergraduate mission must and will not be turned aside by any agreement with CGU.’”

Source: Bryan Alexander, “Campus cuts, closures, mergers, and layoffs for winter 2025-2026.” <https://bryanalexander.org/horizon-scanning/campus-cuts-closures-mergers-and-layoffs-for-winter-2025-2026/>

10.4 The Bifurcation

The LAC sector is splitting into two distinct categories:

- **Fortress schools (top ~20)**: Endowments exceeding \$500K/student, acceptance rates under 15%, no existential threat
- **Vulnerable schools (100+ others)**: Tuition-dependent, enrollment-sensitive, geographically isolated, many facing closure

“Only 7% of students indicated they chose to enroll in a liberal arts institution.”

Source: Encoura/Eduventures, “Redefining the Value of Liberal Arts Institutions,” October 2024. <https://www.encoura.org/resources/wake-up-call/redefining-the-value-of-liberal-arts-institutions/>

11. Structural Vulnerability: LACs and Engineering

Most top LACs do not offer engineering degrees. As students shift from CS toward engineering (the fastest-growing field at +7.3% in Fall 2025), this creates a structural gap:

School	Engineering Program	CS Program
Swarthmore	✓ ABET-accredited	✓
Harvey Mudd	✓ Engineering focus	✓
Williams	✗	✓
Amherst	✗	✓
Pomona	✗ (access via Harvey Mudd consortium)	✓
Bowdoin	✗ (3-2 joint programs with Columbia, Dartmouth, Cal-tech)	✓

12. Alumni Wellbeing and the Gallup Evidence

12.1 The Gallup-Purdue Index (now Gallup Alumni Survey)

Since 2014, Gallup has surveyed a nationally representative sample of 100,000+ U.S. college graduates, measuring workplace engagement and five dimensions of wellbeing (career, social, financial, physical, community). The key findings cut both ways for LACs:

No institutional-type effect on outcomes:

“The type of schools these college graduates attended — public or private, small or large, very selective or less selective — hardly matters at all to their workplace engagement and current well-being.”

“Just as many graduates of public colleges as graduates of not-for-profit private colleges are engaged at work.”

Researchers found “a roughly 1 percentage point difference” between Ivy League schools and other colleges, which was “not statistically significant.”

What does matter: the “Big Six” experiences:

Graduates who had three key supportive relationships (a professor who cared about them as a person, made them excited about learning, and encouraged them to pursue their dreams) had **double** the odds of being engaged at work and **nearly triple** the odds of thriving in wellbeing. Graduates who had three experiential learning opportunities (a long-term project, an internship, and extreme involvement in extracurriculars) had **double** the odds of being engaged.

Only 3% of graduates nationally had all six experiences.

Source: Gallup-Purdue Index Report, 2014. <https://www.luminafoundation.org/files/resources/gallup-purdue-index-report-2014.pdf>; Gallup, “Life in College Matters for Life After College,” 2014.

12.2 The Gallup-Bates Purposeful Work Study (2019)

Gallup and Bates College jointly studied purpose in work among college graduates:

“80% of college graduates said that it is very important or extremely important to derive a sense of purpose from their work. Less than half had succeeded in finding it.”

Four college experiences were most strongly associated with finding purpose: (1) an applied job or internship, (2) someone who encouraged them to pursue their goals, (3) realistic expectations for post-graduation employment, and (4) a class or program that helped them think about finding meaning in work.

“Graduates with high levels of purpose are nearly 10 times more likely to have high levels of overall wellbeing.”

Source: Gallup and Bates College, *Forging Pathways to Purposeful Work: The Role of Higher Education*, April 2019. <https://tacc.org/sites/default/files/documents/2019-04/purposefulwork.pdf>

12.3 What This Means for LACs

The Gallup evidence is a double-edged sword:

- **The case for LACs:** Small classes, close faculty relationships, undergraduate research, and mentorship are exactly the conditions that produce the “Big Six” experiences. LACs are structurally better positioned to deliver these than large research universities with 300-student lecture halls.
- **The case against:** Gallup found no statistically significant difference in outcomes by institution type. This suggests that *having* the structural conditions isn’t enough — what matters is whether individual students actually experience them. The fact that only 3% of graduates nationally had all six experiences implies even LACs are not universally delivering on their promise.
- **Surprising finding:** Graduates of smaller schools were “slightly *less* likely to be engaged at work than those from schools with enrollments larger than 10,000.” Gallup’s Brandon Busteed called this “a stumper.”

13. The International Liberal Arts Experiment: Yale-NUS

Yale-NUS College, a joint venture between Yale University and the National University of Singapore (NUS), opened in 2013 as one of the first residential liberal arts colleges in Asia. It accepted its last class in 2021 and officially closed on June 30, 2025.

The closure was unilateral. NUS announced in August 2021 that Yale-NUS would be merged with NUS’s University Scholars Programme to form “NUS College.” The successor institution dropped liberal arts subjects from its core curriculum.

Key factors in the failure:

1. **Governance mismatch.** NUS retained ultimate authority. Yale had brand involvement but not operational control. When NUS decided to restructure, Yale had no veto.
2. **Academic freedom tensions.** Singapore’s political context limited the kind of open inquiry central to the liberal arts model. The clash between liberal arts pedagogy and authoritarian governance norms was never resolved.
3. **Lack of cultural fit.** Students were drawn from a system that values specialization and credential-specificity; the open curriculum model had limited local demand.

Lesson for the LAC sector: the residential liberal arts model appears to be contextually dependent on the American (or at minimum, Anglo-American) cultural and institutional ecosystem. It does not straightforwardly export.

Sources: Wikipedia, “Yale-NUS College” (citing NUS and Yale institutional statements); Duke University Lily Pad, “Lessons Learned from the Closure of Yale-NUS,” February 2024; *Yale Daily News*, “The Narratives of Yale-NUS,” April 2022.

14. The AI Argument: Both Sides

14.1 The Pro-LAC Argument

The standard claim: as AI automates technical tasks, the human skills cultivated by liberal arts education — critical thinking, ethical reasoning, communication, judgment — become *more* scarce and therefore more valuable.

AAC&U and Morning Consult (August 2025) surveyed 1,030 executives and hiring managers:

“93% of employers rate written and oral communications, critical thinking and ethical judgement/decision-making as important on the list of skills they seek in recent college graduates.”

NACE Job Outlook 2025: nearly 90% of employers seek evidence of problem-solving; ~80% value teamwork and written communication.

Sources: AAC&U/Morning Consult employer survey, August 2025; NACE Job Outlook 2025; *U.S. News*, “Why AI Makes a Liberal Arts Education Even More Invaluable,” January 2026.

14.2 The Counterargument

The pro-LAC AI narrative is contested on three fronts:

1. **AI also automates communication, analysis, and synthesis.** The World Economic Forum (January 2026): “AI has now introduced a fourth, digital world... As a tool, AI automates analysis, argumentation and hard intellectual labour. Any student who wishes to avoid the deep engagement with texts required to write college-level assignments can do so.” If AI can write clearly and reason about ethics, the scarcity value of those skills *decreases*, not increases.
2. **Entry-level hollowing.** AEI senior fellow Brent Orrell: AI is “hollowing out precisely those entry-level analytical tasks that have traditionally served as training grounds for professional judgment.” The liberal

arts pipeline assumes graduates will develop judgment through early-career apprenticeship — but if those entry-level roles disappear, the pipeline breaks.

3. **Expertise matters more, not less, but the gap is unforgiving.** *Times Higher Education* (March 2026): “The gap between what a novice and an expert can produce with AI is wider than the gap between what they could produce without it.” A mediocre liberal arts graduate using AI still produces mediocre work. The advantage goes to those who can *evaluate* AI output — which requires deep domain knowledge, not just broad exposure.

The honest assessment: the AI question is genuinely open. The theoretical argument for liberal arts is plausible, but so is the counterargument. Neither side has strong empirical evidence yet. Treating the pro-LAC AI narrative as “strong” (as the original draft did) is premature.

Sources: World Economic Forum, “In the age of AI, human skills are the new advantage,” January 2026; *Washington Monthly*, “What AI Can’t Do,” April 2026; *Times Higher Education*, “AI’s mediocrity makes liberal arts’ critical thinking essential,” March 2026.

15. Key Open Questions

1. **Does the AI economy ultimately reward liberal arts graduates?** The theoretical argument is plausible but the counterargument is equally strong. Market evidence is thin as of May 2026. (See Section 14.)
2. **Will the CS enrollment decline benefit or hurt LACs?** LACs recently built CS capacity; if CS loses appeal, they may lose a pipeline — but if the value shifts from coding to judgment, their broader model may be vindicated.
3. **Is the PhD per-capita advantage durable?** The per-capita lead persists but absolute numbers are declining. The real question is whether the PhD pipeline contraction (Section 4.6) is making this metric less relevant to students even as it remains statistically favorable to LACs.
4. **Can the career funnel be broken?** Binder’s research is a decade old and has been cited 300+ times, yet institutions have taken no meaningful action to diversify career pathways. Does career funneling operate the same way at a 2,000-student LAC as at a 6,000-student Ivy? The Williams 26.4% finance figure suggests yes, but the mechanism (“platinum” recruitment partnerships) may function differently.
5. **What happens to racial diversity at elite LACs?** SFFA has produced a 16.3% decline in Black freshmen at highly selective institutions (Section 3E). This directly undermines the strongest causal finding from the research — that elite colleges produce the largest mobility gains for Black and Hispanic students. If the students who benefit most from attending LACs are increasingly not attending them, the social mobility case weakens.
6. **Are LAC earnings understated or accurately measured?** The College Scorecard data (Section 3A.1) shows top LACs earning well above the national median but below elite research universities. The higher rates of graduate school attendance (Revelio Labs: LAC graduates are 2x more likely to enter PhD programs) depress 10-year earnings metrics. Longer-horizon data from Georgetown CEW (40-year ROI) tells a different story. The question is which timeframe prospective students and families should optimize for.
7. **Does the Gallup evidence undermine the LAC value proposition?** The finding that institutional type is statistically irrelevant to workplace engagement and wellbeing (Section 12.1) is uncomfortable for institutions charging \$85,000/year on the premise that they deliver a transformatively different experience.

The counterargument — that LACs are structurally better positioned to deliver the “Big Six” experiences — is plausible but unproven at scale.

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ID	Source	Type	Date
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S3	NSF InfoBrief NSF 08-311	Federal analysis	2008
S4	Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Labor Market for Recent College Graduates	Federal data	Continuously updated; 2023 Census data
S5	Binder AJ et al., “Career Funneling,” <i>Sociology of Education</i> 89(1)	Peer-reviewed	2016
S6	Rivera LA, <i>Pedigree</i> , Princeton University Press	Academic book	2015
S7	Dale SB, Krueger AB, <i>Quarterly Journal of Economics</i> 117(4)	Peer-reviewed	2002
S8	Dale SB, Krueger AB, <i>Journal of Human Resources</i> 49(2)	Peer-reviewed	2014
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S75	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S76	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S77	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S78	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S79	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S80	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S81	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S82	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S83	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S84	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S85	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S86	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S87	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S88	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S89	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S90	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S91	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S92	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S93	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S94	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S95	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S96	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S97	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S98	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025
S99	Georgetown CEW, <i>ROI of Liberal Arts Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	January 2020
S100	Georgetown CEW, <i>Ranking 4,600 Colleges</i>	Federal data analysis	February 2025

These notes synthesize publicly available data and peer-reviewed research. All quoted passages are verbatim from their cited sources. Interpretive claims are flagged as such.

Revision Log

- **2026-05-22:** Initial compilation (Sections 1–12).
- **2026-05-23:** Added Sections 3A (Earnings/ROI), 3B (Social Mobility), 3C (Graduation Rates), 3D (Professional School Outcomes), 3E (SFFA Impact), 4.6 (PhD Decline Causes), 12 (Gallup Wellbeing), 13 (Yale-NUS), 14 (AI Both Sides). Expanded Section 5.4 (conflation critique). Replaced weak sources (AdmissionSight → CDS, Wikiwand → NACUBO). Added 20 source entries (S22–S42). Expanded Key Open Questions (Section 15).